

Why We Regret: Choice, Time, and Becoming

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Regret is a word that we usually pronounce quietly. It carries the weight of failure, of choices misunderstood in hindsight, of paths not taken. We are taught to associate regret with poor judgment, as if our past selves should have known better.

However, regret does not necessarily signal irrationality. It can also be understood as the natural consequence of decision-making over time of inter-temporal choice made under bounded rationality and imperfect information. We choose with what we know, who we are, and what we value in that moment. When we are young, both the world and the self is imperfectly understood. Most of the time while deciding, future is not merely uncertain, it can be unimaginable. We do not yet know what kind of work will feel meaningful over decades, what trade-offs we will later regret accepting or refusing, or which aspects of our identity will remain central as we grow older. Evaluating alternatives therefore requires projecting oneself into lives one has never lived with values one has not yet formed. In such conditions, choice is necessarily speculative.

When we look back, we evaluate our past choices using the knowledge, values, and perspective we have today, and we implicitly assume that this perspective was always accessible. In doing so, we erase the constraints under which the original decision was made. Even seemingly small decisions, what we choose to study, how we spend our free time, whether we exercise or not, what we eat for breakfast, accumulate overtime and help shape who we become. As a result, regret becomes less about the choice itself and more about an unfair comparison between who we were and who we have since become.

Preferences in early life are not stable parameters; they are shaped through experience itself. Many choices are made precisely while identity is still under construction, meaning that the act of choosing contributes to defining who the decision-maker becomes. What later appears as a misalignment between choice and values often reflects the fact that those values did not yet exist in their current form. The person capable of identifying the “better” option ex post is frequently the product of the very path that is later questioned. Regret, in this sense, is inseparable from growth: it arises because preferences evolve, not because earlier choices violated them.

These internal constraints are reinforced by the way time and social incentives are perceived early in life. The future tends to feel distant and abstract, while immediate outcomes are concrete and emotionally salient. Approval, belonging, excitement, and relief carry real weight, not because of immaturity, but because they are immediately experienced. Social pressure, often dismissed retrospectively as weakness, functioned at the time as a rational response to the costs of exclusion and uncertainty. Ignoring these incentives would not have been neutral; it would have been costly. The fact that their importance diminishes over time does not mean they were distortions when the decision was made.

This understanding is substantiated by empirical evidence. Studies in behavioral economics and psychology have consistently demonstrated that human decision-making is constrained by incomplete information, cognitive limitations, and changing preferences. Herbert Simon's notion of bounded rationality posits that individuals do not seek to optimize across all potential outcomes; rather, they make satisfactory choices based on their current knowledge and cognitive capacity. Likewise, research conducted by Daniel Kahneman and Amos Tversky illustrates how hindsight bias causes individuals to overrate the predictability of past occurrences once the outcomes are revealed.

Even once we acknowledge the constraints under which decisions are made, regret often survives in a subtler form. We continue to imagine that an alternative path, another degree, another city, another relationship, might have led to a cleaner, more successful, or more fulfilled version of ourselves. These imagined lives appear coherent and effortless, free of the difficulties that characterize the path we took. In hindsight, the road not chosen often looks not only different, but objectively better.

This perception, however, rests on a selective reconstruction of the past. When we imagine alternative choices, we rarely imagine alternative costs. The unrealized path is evaluated using today's knowledge and values, but without the uncertainty, sacrifices, and trade-offs that would have accompanied it in real time. We project our current self into a counterfactual world, assuming that the person we are now would have emerged unchanged under different circumstances. In doing so, we strip the alternative of the very constraints that shaped the original one.

Psychological research on counterfactual thinking helps explain this tendency. Because imagined outcomes are not constrained by lived experience, they can be optimized in ways real lives cannot. The difficulties, failures, and unintended consequences that inevitably accompany any path remain invisible. The alternative life becomes a mental construction rather than a genuine possibility, a version of events in which uncertainty has been resolved, risks have paid off, and growth has occurred without friction.

The skills developed, the values clarified, and even the dissatisfaction experienced along the way shape the criteria by which alternatives are judged. What appears, in retrospect, as a "better" option often only qualifies as such because of who the decision-maker has become. Had a different path been taken, a different self with different preferences and sensitivities would have emerged, evaluating outcomes according to a different standard altogether.

The illusion of the better option arises from perceiving identity as permanent while imagining alternatives as variable. Actually, they are inseparable. Options shape identity, which in turn shapes how options are evaluated. To regret a prior decision because of the person one has become ignores the fact that this person may not have existed without that decision. The perceived superiority of the road not chosen is thus not evidence of a mistake, but rather the result of hindsight applied to a self that is fundamentally path dependent. If you feel regret, it is tempting to read it as a verdict, proof that you chose poorly, that you failed to see what now appears obvious. But regret does not emerge from irrationality alone. It emerges from distance. It appears when you look back with a clarity that was unavailable to you at the moment of choice.

When regret surfaces, it does not necessarily point to a mistake waiting to be corrected. More often, it reflects the fact that you have changed. Seen this way, regret becomes less a condemnation of the past and more a recognition of becoming. It doesn't tell you that you should have known better, but that you now know more and that knowledge could only have been earned by living forward before it could ever be understood in hindsight.

References

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